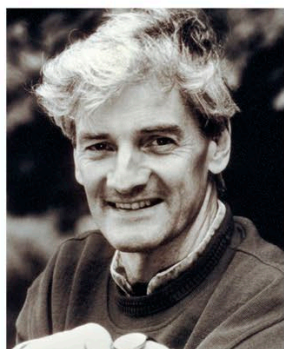


James Dyson



One of the most successful British inventors of recent decades, James Dyson has created numerous devices for use both inside and outside the home, most notably the cyclonic vacuum cleaner. All his inventions have a similar backstory—Dyson spotted a flaw in an existing, widely used device and decided that he could come up with innovations to improve it.

► IN THE WORKSHOP

Dyson's workshops have created more than 50 types of cyclonic cleaner, from giant industrial machines to handheld versions.

THE BALLBARROW

Dyson's first major inventing success was a new type of wheelbarrow. He was inspired to create the product by his experiences of getting the narrow wheel of his own barrow stuck in the mud while gardening. Dyson solved the problem by replacing the wheel with a plastic ball, which spread the load, making the barrow easier to use on soft ground.



The ball at the front of the barrow makes it simpler to steer.

THE CYCLONIC VACUUM CLEANER

In 1978, Dyson set about inventing a bagless vacuum cleaner based on cyclonic technology (see p.201). He built 5,127 prototypes before he had a working version. Dyson's first cyclonic cleaner, the G-Force, was launched in Japan in the mid-1980s. A later version, the Dyson DC01, became a global phenomenon, prompting other companies to produce their own cyclonic cleaners.



The Contrarotator's two drums had more than 5,000 holes to remove water quickly.

FAILURES

Along with his successes, Dyson suffered a few failures, including the Contrarotator (also known as the CR01) washing machine in 2000. It had two counter-rotating drums, which were meant to spin clothes drier than other models. However, it was expensive and sold poorly. Its production was stopped after a few years.

TIMELINE

1947

Dyson is born on May 2. He goes on to study furniture design and interior design at the Royal College of Art in the 1960s.

1970

While studying, he helps to design the Rotork Sea Truck, a high-speed landing craft used by the British military.

1974

Dyson sets up a company to manufacture his first successful invention, the Ballbarrow, which wins the Building Design Innovation Award in 1977.

1978

He starts working on developing the cyclonic vacuum cleaner. By 1983, he has produced a model, but he is unable to find a manufacturer to invest in his product.